

SAMUEL
COLT

GREAT GUNSMITHS

COLT

American manufacturer Samuel Colt (1814–62) built his first revolver in 1831, when he was just sixteen. He perfected the design over a number of years, eventually founding the successful Colt's Patent Fire Arms Manufacturing Company. Colt's designs played a major role in the history of US firearms, leading the change from single-shot pistols to revolvers. As one of the first to make mass production work on a large, commercial scale, Colt also pioneered manufacturing methods that transformed industry worldwide.

In the first half of the 19th century, American inventors made attempts at developing the concept of the revolver, with its rotating cylinder that turns to bring one of several chambers in line with the barrel. Inventor Elisha Collier, who was attracted by the revolver's ability to fire several shots without reloading, designed a flintlock revolver (see p.49) in about 1814. It became popular, especially in Britain, but its unreliable mechanism was a drawback. Samuel Colt was the first to unite the revolver concept with the more reliable percussion-cap mechanism. In the 1830s and early 1840s, Colt made various attempts at manufacturing his revolver, which he patented in 1835. However, the quality of his products was uneven, and none of these enterprises was successful.

MASS PRODUCTION

In 1847, Colt made a new start, renting premises in Connecticut before opening a specially built factory by the Connecticut River

“Abe Lincoln may have freed all men, but Sam Colt made them equal.”

POST-CIVIL WAR SLOGAN

in 1855. Here he developed mass production, building each gun from identical parts that could be put together on an assembly line. This kind of manufacturing had already been pioneered by other American industrialists, particularly other firearms producers and Connecticut clockmakers, but Colt was one of the first to adopt it on a large scale. His streamlined production methods enabled the Colt factory to fulfill large orders, not just in the US but also in Europe, where its sales increased during the Crimean War (1853–56).

Making the interchangeable parts for Colt's revolvers involved the development of specialized, state-of-the-art machinery. Colt

hired a skilled mechanic and inventor, Elisha K. Root, to oversee his manufacturing process and design the machinery needed. Soon Root was producing a host of mechanized tools, such as milling machines, drill presses, and specially built lathes. In the factory's first year, one observer counted no fewer than 400 different machine tools, most of which carried out processes that had previously been done by hand. This type of highly mechanized production of interchangeable parts was hugely influential in all kinds of industries, including the production of farm machinery, sewing machines, bicycles, steam engines, railroad locomotives, and automobiles. Manufacturers who used it found not only that they kept down their costs, but also that their products were reliable and easy to repair. The mass-production techniques pioneered by Colt transformed not just the firearms business but the whole of industry.

WINNING THE WEST

Colt's mass-produced revolvers were hugely popular. They sold not only to military users, but also to those involved in law enforcement and to individuals for self-defense. The Colt was especially popular among the settlers of the American West, and the most successful model

◀ CRIME CONFERENCE

The importance of the Colt company continued through the 20th century. Here, Newton D. Baker (left) attends a Crime Commission meeting in Chicago and examines the weapons used by the city's gunmen and bootleggers.

